Cognitive Homelessness and Maximizing the Unexpected

#planningformistakes #wandering

Decision theory derives from a long tradition in consequentialism and epistemology. As such, it is rooted across two drastically divergent paths. Philosophers are often concerned with normative questions about how people should decide to act rather than descriptive ones about how they in fact do decide to act. However, many authors have pointed out that normative decision theory cannot always guide us through important decisions (LA Paul 2015a; 2015b; Rust, 2025; Carter 2026). These authors have argued that normative decision theories are impossible because we often have imperfect access to our own epistemic states (cf. Jackson 1991; Howard-Snyder 1997; Lenman 2000). Increasingly, these epistemic states are seen to have important implications for our moral states. Paul (2015a; 2015b) argues that personally transformative decisions are generally inaccessible experiences that are opaque to us until we've had the right experience. Some other authors, however, have argued that narrative gives us access to such states (Nussbaum 1986; Altshuler 2021; Nussbaum 1983; Goldie 2003, 2009; Stump 2010). I want to tackle perhaps the most important decision we could make, deciding whether or not we are in love. At once, these kinds of decisions are difficult since they obscure the chasm between our moral and epistemic states. For instance, because such cases are transformative, it is often easier to determine if we are in love when we are in love, and out of love when we are out of it (Carter 2026, p. 9; also see Rust 2025). Here, the epistemic weight of such questions are ground in the moral impact of the same.

How do we determine the meaning of concepts like love? On one view, love is a physiological chemical process occurring with machine-like frequency in a self-contained system (Brogaard 2015, p. 38). However, there are many reasons to think that this view of the emotion is unsuccessful. To see why, it may first help to understand the nature of suffering. To do this, we would first look at the traditional problem of evil, substituting evil with suffering.

1. There is suffering in the world.
2. There is an omniscient, omnipotent, perfectly good God.
3. There is no morally sufficient reason for an omniscient, omnipotent, perfectly good God to allow suffering in the world.

But what is suffering? Like love, we need to know how we should determine what suffering is. One option is to identify the physical properties underlying the state in question. For instance, if we understand what the brain is like when a person suffers, then we will be in a better position to know what suffering suffering is. However, this tells us what the objective status of suffering is, but not the subjective, which is what we want because while suffering is a state, its source is varied, it can either be an objective brain state, or a subjective experience. For instance, when looking at the common standard definition of pain, pains are experiences "commonly associated with tissue damage or potential tissue damage" (Aydede 2017, 2019).

Second, remember that we initially substituted evil with suffering. But what this represents is a conflation of sorts, between pain and suffering. One possibility is that unlike pain, suffering is always negatively valanced, never desirable whether in and of itself, or prudentially. Someone training for a marathon may experience pain, but we shouldn't equate their experience with suffering. This position is not the default and there are some who disagree. On these accounts, there may be some goods associated with suffering. For instance, it may be that suffering tells us some important fact about our environment. If our eyes begin to water from the smoke in the air, then we need to get to a place where there is fresh air. We might say then that suffering is motivational or central to rationality, that it motivates fitness preserving behavior, or that suffering strengthens rational activity (Fulkerson and Cohen 2020). What asks is whether suffering is a different kind of experience than pain. Unlike suffering, it may be the case that we have instrumental reasons for pursuing painful experiences, like running a marathon. These are realized by their ability to provide us with motivation, or to strengthen rational activity. The pain of receiving a non-optimal grade on a test will encourage me to refrain from drinking the night before a test in the future or that pain helps me to recognize what I truly value. I thought that I valued excessive drinking, but once I received the non-optimal grade, I realize that what I value truly is receiving optimal grades. But there is no reason to suppose that such experiences are synonymous with suffering.

Unlike pain, there are no instrumental reasons for suffering. While some may only reserve these kinds of conclusions for the most egregious forms of suffering, I do not see any reason why we should do so. There have been suggestions in this area, such as suffering produces character, but this does not seem to be right. If it is producing character, then maybe it is not quite suffering these positions are considering since there is some redeeming benefit, and the victims of suffering are incapable of perceiving the benefits they've gotten from suffering. For one, producing character implies rational agency. So if suffering produces character, then suffering does not preclude rational activity. A rational agent is still capable of appreciating how bad something is (Adams 2020, 282). But there are many forms of pain that do preclude rational activity. For instance, victims who without therapy and lots of support, are incapable of recognizing that what was done to them as harmful (Stump 2010, 8; Burkett 1997). In other words, suffering, as we should consider it here, does preclude rational activity. Further, the person who is suffering, is not in a position to realize just how bad their situation really is owing to the lack of their rationally activity. What this shows I will argue, is that there is reason to believe there may be a qualitative difference between suffering and pain and that this qualitative difference is the difference between rational activity and irrational activity.

Rational choice theory asks "can an agent always expect to do best by trying to do whatever has the most expected value?" Eleonore Stump raises the question of value. In her account of closeness and presence from her book, Wandering in Darkness, Eleonore Stump argues that love is an interaction of "two mutually governing desires for the good of the beloved and the desire for union with the beloved" (Stump 2010, 95). She then considers reasons why rational choice theory may fail. Psychic fragmentation can leave a person alienated from herself and therefore alienated from her own two mutually governing desires. The best example of this can be represented with the following lyric excerpts from the songs "By Yourself" by Tyrone Griffin Jr (Ty Dollar $ign Diggs) and "Rich and Sad" by Austin Richard Post (Post Malone).

First,

Orthodox decision theory recommends acting in a way that maximizes expected value:

- "Stacked your bread and bought your own Mercedes (Vroom, vroom)."
- "You your own boss, do it your way (Way)"[1]

But we often get our expected values wrong:

- "Got a hundred big places, but I'm still alone (–one)"
- "All this stuntin' couldn't satisfy my soul (–oul)"[2]

Orthodox decision theory recommends acting in a way that maximizes actual or expected value. Some of the decisions that we make are of extreme importance to the way that our lives are going to go. When deciding to accept a job offer, I am not only concerned with the amount of pay the job offers. Rather, I also want to consider whether or not accepting the job offer would require me to move away from my home town, I might ask whether and how often I would still be able to visit old friends and family members, I might ask myself what kind of neighborhood I would have to move to, or what kind of persons I would work with or for. I will ask whether any of my future coworkers will be friendly, accommodating to new relationships, accepting of new members to their friend group, etc.

Centrally, maximization and value are drawn from the premise that each person's locus of action is that their life go as well as possible for them (see, Parfit 1987). But the problem is that these decisions have such an impact that they change you. In effect, these decisions then only impact someone not yourself. L.A. Paul imagines the decision to become a vampire. What is important here is that once you become a vampire, you can't undo the effect that the experience will have on your life. As such, one reason why we get our values wrong, is that we do not know what the values of the person we are deciding for are, assuming that the person we are deciding for is some future person. Whatever we decide, will be decided for that person.

[1] *By Yourself*. 2020. With Ty Dolla $ign, Jhené Aiko, and Mustard. Atlantic Records.

[2] Malone, Post. 2018. *Rich & Sad*. Beerbongs & Bentleys. Republic Records, a division of UMG Recordings, Inc., 2018.

Similarly, once you are in love, you cannot undo the effect the experience will have on your life because it will no longer belong to you. In other words, you are not making the decision for yourself, but for "that person". I generalize such experiences to include the relationships we build around us. When making most of our decisions about such relationships, whether political, organizational, occupational, academic, we assess varying possibilities between them. Each possibility has implications for that person but not for who we are now, not necessarily for us.

As such, the decision itself is drastically transformative. What effect will my potential new friend-group have on who I am, the kind of person I am now. Will this effect be positive? Can I see myself growing, developing new skills, perhaps learn a new language, develop new personal interests? Because of these kinds of questions, whatever choice I will make will be transformative, we can't know what the varying possibilities are like. In other words, the effects that the decision will have on us, the effect of the experience of having made the decision, will have on us, is opaque.

This also means that our credences with regard to what we value, are opaque to us and therefore we cannot identify those acts which maximize actual or expected value (Carter 2026; cf. Smith 2010; Srinivasan 2015; Lasonen-Aarnio 2019;2024; Lasonen 2025; Hughes 2021). Some decisions require such access however. The implication here is that we should always choose to do that action that we believe will produce the most value. However, "doing whatever will provide the most value" is often hard (See Lewis, 1981; also see Carter; 2026; Gallow 2021; and Isaacs *et al* 2023; also see Smith 2010.). It is argued that we do not have access to the world in a way that would allow us to follow through on our plans to maximize value (especially see, Gallow, 2021, p. 3), but as I've argued here, this is because the access to the world that we seek, is not yet here.

Therefore, we have uneven evidence in that our confidence towards genuine personal states of value, what we value now, are often higher than our confidence towards illusory personal states of value, what we will value in the future (Lasonen-Aarnio 2015; Salow 2018; Isaacs and Russell 2023). One outcome in such cases, is that it is often easier to be confident that we are in love, when we are in fact in love, than it is to be confident that we are out of love, when we are in fact, not in love. We often assign equal credence towards states of value we are in, whether genuine or illusory (Lasonen-Aarnio 2015; Salow 2018; Isaacs and Russell 2023). An opaque decision problem represents the situation of an agent who must decide what to do while being (potentially) uncertain about their own credences (Carter, 2026, 3).

We might follow some plan of action, take the job and move to a new city, only to find out that the promised outcome is not what we desired after all, we hate both our job and the new city we find ourselves in. Such mistakes in judgment then, stem from failures to recognize our own future priorities. Therefore standard normative decision theories cannot always guide us through important decisions (LA Paul 2015a; 2015b; Carter 2026) and decision theory proposes an answer.

There are many versions of this concern, however most of these fail to accommodate the problematic states as ones belonging to future versions of ourselves. But there may be some plausible explanation of these outcomes. For instance, let's imagine that on the basis of a coinflip, we will either be shown a genuine or a counterfeit Rothko. If we are shown the counterfeit but not the genuine version, we would be less likely to question its authenticity having no belief about the real one. We assign equal credence to either possibility, that the Rotko before us a genuine or a fake. Therefore, we might mistakenly think that upon looking at a counterfeit Rothko, that we desire to bid on the counterfeit Rothko rather than a genuine one (Carter, 2026, p. 9). What this means is that in the Rothko case, we have no reason to assume that the one we are bidding on is a counterfeit since it is the only one. This shows a different version of the problem, where we have no reason to value a different state of affairs since there is only one facing us.

Consequently then, we might think that the value state we are deciding on, is for us a genuine value. From where we stand, New York has always been a very attractive destination for us. Having grown up in a small rust-belt town, we've always wanted to move to New York. We can see ourselves as urbanites and the thought has always been attractive to us.

The kind of common mistake that we make, which is important for Stump's thesis, is that an opaque decision problem with respect to decision theory concerns special personal relationships. If we are confronted with two alternative versions of ourselves, then we would have more reason to question whether one is genuine or not.

According to Orthodox decision theory, agents like us should follow the condition on their credences which is both necessary and sufficient for maximizing expected value (Carter, 2026, p. 4). However, Orthodox decision theory is not always good advice for agents like us. Agents like us are susceptible to error. For agents like us then, who are susceptible to error, there can be situations in which trying to do what has the most expected value (follow MEV), will leave us worse off. Imagine that the following represents: Doing whatever has the most expected value for a given agent

- "Stacked [my] bread and bought my own Mercedes (Vroom, vroom). [I'm my] own boss, do it [my] way (Way)[3]

and then getting it wrong

- "All this stuntin' couldn't satisfy my soul (–oul), Got a hundred big places, but I'm still alone (–one)"

While such decisions may not be practically decided on, being in valuing a friendship versus not valuing a friendship. Given our susceptibility to error, it is then important to show which framework works best for evaluating advice. Following Stump, I argue that they may be narratively decided on (e.g., also see Rust 2025).

[3]Pronouns in brakets are altered from the origional. In it, the spaker addresses these to single women.

The Nature of Love and Suffering

Using Stump 2010, I will argue that a rational decision theory then may be improved by a narrative decision theory of rational choice.

Eleonore Stump defends a two-part Thomistic account of personal identity. A person's first-order desires reflect the *reasons* she has to take something as good whereas their second-order desires reflect the kind of will they want to have. She then contrasts a metaphysics of personal identity which gives a special focus to the rational faculties that a person possesses, where a person's attribution of value is correlated with some particular action in some particular circumstance and a psychology of personal identity where a person's attribution of value is correlated with general reasons of action grounded in their value of a good will.

Shame is the connection between moral wrongdoing and some defect of the will since it undermines our ability to experience fruitful and deep relationships with others. If I am guilty of stealing from a friend out of necessity, it will be difficult for me to face that individual and our relationship will be strained. If I desire union with the other person, then I will feel shame given that I expect rejection and abandonment by them. Over time however, I may not feel shame any longer. This is because I will no longer desire a relationship with that person.

The remedy may be to repair the will, but sometimes it is not possible for a person's will to change. Notice here that the temptation to steal from the friend came by way of perceived necessity, and therefore outside of my control. This highlights the difference between shame and guilt. I will feel guilt out of my anticipation to be the object of anger or punishment whereas I experience shame when I am anticipating abandonment or rejection. I experience shame out of my desire to be loved by others and conviction that something about me warrants their rejection of me. Therefore, because the perceived infraction was outside of my control, repairing the shame too is outside of my control.

The remedy for shame rests in the need of paired processes of justification and sanctification. Importantly, as a response to the problem of evil, Stump recommends an account of friendship for psychological well-being, where this friendship is grounded in union with God.

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A problem with this account, is that it rests on theological commitment. However, it in itself is not sufficient for justifying theistic beliefs. As a response to the problem of evil, it suffers because it needs a defense of theistic belief. But perhaps a better way to understand it is teleological. A path forward, is to think of the response as an definition of suffering. What is bad about suffering is that it undermines or destroys what the sufferer centrally cares about, whether they realize it or not.

- her own flourishing
- the desires of her heart
- or both

Standard Decision Formulas

Rational choice theory says "choose the act with the highest expected utility." This results in us having uneven evidence in that our confidence towards genuine personal states of value are often higher than our confidence towards illusory personal states of value (Lasonen-Aarnio 2015; Salow 2018; Isaacs and Russell 2023). While however, such decisions may not be practically decided on, being in love versus not being in love, they may be narratively decided on (Rust 2025).

According to rational decision theory, the expected utility of some action depends of the probability that the state of affairs which obtains, is the relevant one. However, complicating this, is the probability that the outcome would be considered valuable by the agent.

		states	states
		it rains	it does not rain
acts	take umbrella	encumbered, dry	encumbered, dry
acts	leave umbrella	wet	free, dry

The expected utility of an act A (for instance, taking my umbrella)

depends on two features of the problem: * The value of each outcome, measured by a real number called a utility. * The probability of each outcome conditional on the act. * roughly, how likely it is that outcome will occur, on the supposition that the agent chooses act A

$$EU(A) = \sum_{o \in O} P_A(o) \cdot U(o)$$

When confronted with personally transformative decisions, we often have imperfect access to our own epistemic states (Carter, 2026; cf. Jackson 1991; Howard-Snyder 1997; Lenman 2000). Therefore we must often make decisions under conditions of uncertainty. But this uncertainty includes:

- Probability the agent will choose act a
- Probability the agent will find outcome o valuable.

The expected value of an action at some state s, is the sum of values of the outcomes produced by that action at each state (Carter, 2026, p. 4). We weight the sum of values according to the probability that is assigned to that state from the perspective of that state (Carter, 2026, p. 4).

A plan to maximize expected value then recommends, in each state, one of the acts which has optimal expected value at that state.

The way an agent acts depends on the plan they are trying to follow. However, given uneven evidence, agents like us who are susceptible to error do not always act according to what their plan recommends for the state they are in. Where any state $s, [s]$ represents an agent whose act is determined according to what their plan recommends for s and an enriched state, $(s, [s'])$ represents the circumstances of an agent who is in s but whose act is determined according to what their plan recommends for s'. Sets of states in the enriched state space can be thought of as propositions which can tell us about:

1. what the world is like
2. what the agent will act as if the world is like.

Evidence to the contrary is the kind of evidence a person needs that what they desire is not in fact what they desire. A special component of this, is the fact that the evidence we need, evidence to the contrary, is not always available to us. We can imagine some agent that wants to believe some proposition p about themselves, for instance that they desire not a meaningful relationship, but a pricey car, but for all p, -p is not a part of the agent's evidence. For all the agent knows, desires consistent with desiring meaningful relationships, are not a part of their evidence set. In this case, an agent has evidence consistent with desiring a pricey car, solely for the reason that evidence consistent with desiring meaningful relationship, is not a part of their evidence set. This is because they may not have access to the necessary counter evidence, that they in fact, desire a meaningful relationship.

Our errors in judgment are often grounded in these more fundamental errors. Another similar example is that we are not vulnerable to love or that we are invulnerable to love. What this means is that a person believes about themselves, that they are not of the sort who "is mushy" or "terribly affectionate", or that they are an extreme introvert, better off alone, etc. Perhaps this person may believe that they can thrive on short-lived, shallow relationships, or just as commonly, no relationship at all.

This has implications for the kinds of decisions that we make. Examples like the one above illustrate a kind of decision problem in which an agent will not expect to do best by trying to follow a plan to maximize expected value. We make a decision thinking that we desire a given outcome. This can include for instance, that we may experience more joy later on by breaking up with our fiancé now because they demand too much of our time. Our time here being a direct and measurable result that can be quantified, for instance to answer the question "how much did I get done today?" On the other hand however, if we spent the day with a loved one, it might be less obvious how to answer such a question according to quantifiable metrics.

Self 1: "How much did I get done today?"

Self 2: "Not much, I just spent the day with my loved one".

Given our relationship with the other, "Not much" and "I just spent the day with my loved one" seem like contradictory statements. The more likely cause of this contradiction is that it is difficult to quantify one's time spent in this manner, but that is not the same as it is to say that it is difficult to qualify one's time spent in this manner. It may just be that rational choice theory does not have a way to qualify one's time spent even though it has a way to quantify one's time spent.

Often it turns out that the outcome that we thought we desired, was not the outcome that we desired should we achieve it. So while it would have been perhaps possible that the agent could have looked for evidence *that* $\neg p$, ***intentionally-biased inquiry, for instance, th****at maybe I am trauma bonding*, intentionally biased inquiry may be impossible The Externalist's Guide to Fishing for Compliments.

Eleonore Stump has argued that love is the interaction of two desires, the first for the good of the beloved and the second, union with the beloved. However, a person often suffers in that they are divided against themselves and so cannot experience desire for the good of the other, or desire for union with another. Desiring the good of, and union with, another places us into a vulnerable state and it is not always clear whether vulnerability in this way is a virtue.

There is a lot of disagreement over what kinds of things we are, whether relationally vulnerable wherein we desire to be with another, or relationally invulnerable where the outcome of not being with another is not a value that we possess, or that it is not a value that overrides other values that we possess. Additionally, *internal integration of the will* would be necessary for love and union with another only if we are relationally vulnerable (Thomas Aquinas, "Adoro devote," in *The Oxford Book of Medieval Latin Verse,* ed. F.J.E. Raby (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1959), 403-4).

This results in a response at having uneven evidence in that our confidence towards genuine personal states of value are often higher than our confidence towards illusory personal states of value (Lasonen-Aarnio 2015; Salow 2018; Isaacs and Russell 2023). While however, such decisions may not be practically decided on, being in love versus not being in love, they may be narratively decided on (Rust 2025).

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